

Farewell Gabbar, thanks for the blockbuster entertainment

Shikhar Dhawan's — **nicknamed Gabbar** — on-field competitiveness mirrors his off-field calm. Retirement at 38 will allow him to pursue his off-field ambitions.

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The Roshanara Club in Delhi holds an iconic place in India's cricket history. It was here that the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) was founded, and the venue has hosted numerous first-class matches. In one such game in 2010, Shikhar Dhawan learnt an unforgettable lesson that would shape his career.

While leading a depleted Delhi team against the Railways, Dhawan, with a comfortable target of 136, played a shot that gave him nightmares for a season or two. His outrageous shot, a wild heave off seamer Anureet Singh, cost him his wicket and Delhi the match. As the only international player on the team, Dhawan had a huge role, but a moment of madness left him the most embarrassed person on the field as Delhi tasted defeat.

Dhawan did not shy away from assuming the responsibility and vowed not to play aerial shots for some time. "*Lift nahi maarni hai* (I will not lift the ball)," he told Delhi team coach Manoj Prabhakar. Matters flared up in the team dressing room, but then it dawned on Prabhakar and Dhawan that they hailed from the same club (Sonnet). Both buried their issues at the Roshanara Club.

Dhawan's determination was far stronger than the challenge he faced. He knew how to stay buoyant. In 2011–12, his scores of 177 and 155 in the Irani Cup match against Rajasthan in Jaipur reignited his confidence, which had been dormant for some time.

His Test debut in 2013 at 27 against Australia was a feat documented by accomplished journalists, coaches, and the many eyes who have longed to witness his stunning demonstrations throughout his career. "I was not surprised," gushed his state coach, Vijay Dahiya. "He has the time to adjust and the range of shots to make a mockery of the opposition."

He successfully filled the void left by Virender Sehwag and Gautam Gambhir. It was almost like nothing had changed, and his ballooning confidence left the Australian side starstruck. One may not be stretching far to say they did not even realise it was his debut. He brought along the same aggression and control that Sehwag was known for. His spectacular 187 was an innings that is hard to erase from memory.

It's hard to overlook the similarity and happenstance of Dhawan stepping in to fill Sehwag's shoes.